The Divided Self by R D Laing

Ronald David Laing was born in Oct 1927 and graduated from Glasgow. He had made an extraordinary argument that the acute mental disorders are advantageous. He analyzed through experimentation the effects of untreated psychosis. His writings include *The Divided Self*(1955), *Self and Others* (1961), *Reason and Violence: A Decade of Sartre's Philosophy* (1964), *The Politics of Experience and the Bird of Paradise* (1967), *Knots* (1971),*The Voice of Experience* (1982), *The Politics of the Family* (1971), *The Facts of Life* (1976), *Do You Love ME?: An Entertainment in Conversation and Verse* (1976), *Conversations with Children* (1978), *Conversations with Adam and Natasha* (1977), *Sonnets*(1979), *Testimony of Experience* (1982), *The Voice of Experience and Wisdom(1982),* and *Madness and Folly: The Making of a Psychiatrist* (1985). He had co-authored *Interpersonal Perception* (1966) and *Sanity, Madness and Family* (1964).

The Divided Self: an Existential Study in Sanity and Madness is a psychological account on madness. The book is divided into three parts. The title of the chapters are "The Existential-Phenomenological Foundations for a Science of Persons", "The Existential-phenomenological Foundations for the Understanding of Psychosis", "Ontological Insecurity", "The Embodied and Unembodied Self", "The Inner Self in the Schizoid Condition", " The False-self System", 'Self-Consciousness", "Psychotic Developments", "The Self and the False Self in a Schizophrenic" and The Ghost of the Weed Garden : a Study of a Chronic Schizophrenia".

The Divided Self is one of the earliest works in existential psychology and psychiatry. It studies, analyzes and theorizes the behaviors of schizoid and schizophrenic persons. The text

aims at making madness and the process of going mad comprehensible. This approach is similar to that of clinical psychiatry and psychopathology.

Laing is using the terms ‘schizoid’ and ‘schizophrenia’ in a phenomenological and existential dimension. A Schizoid is a split individual who can neither stay in peace with external world nor with himself. He suffers from solitude and loneliness and finds it difficult to experience himself with others or at home. Schizophrenia is a condition of continuous and chronic mental illness.

Existential phenomenology analyzes a person’s relation with the external world and himself. Behavioral psychology is the science that studies the behaviors of people which the psychologists believed were acquired through conditioning, i.e, the experiences and surroundings in which the individual lives. According to anthropology, personal behaviors of an individual are the results of his experiences and intensions. People who regard themselves as automata, robots, machinery or animals are inherently believed as crazy.

Laing has made attempts to present real examples by visiting patients and recording their experiences. He claimed that he had only changed the names and residences of patients while all situations mentioned are completely real. He regards madness as a human tragedy. He reported that common people generally have an aversion to psychiatric words. Hence, in the book he tried to avoid technical words wherever possible.

Splits and depersonalizations arise when the psychopathology of individual gets affected. A disorganized person may not be mad, his disorganization maybe the result of his failure to organize. Schizophrenic depersonalizations are intentional acts to a large extent. We cannot always speak objectively about someone; we will occasionally turn out as subjective.

Psychotheraphy, according to Laing, is that activity in which the patient's being and his relatedness to others is used for therapy. According to psychiatrists, psychosis is a "social or biological failure of adjustment or mal-adaptation of a particularly radical kind, of loss of contact with reality, of lack of insight" (27).

Laing found it difficult to understand the real feelings of the patients for their behaviors were often very strange. Most patients are extremely anxious or excited for no reason at all. He admitted that his interpretations will be depended on his relationship with patients and hence they are subjective. Clinical psychiatry offers a formal analysis to recode patients' speeches and behaviors.

According to him, one is prejudiced when one says that he cannot understand a psychotic. "Sanity or psychosis is tested by the degree of conjunction or disjunction between two persons'. One is believed to be sane for everyone believes that he is sane. He is sane by common consent. In the whole life of a psychotic patient, he wishes to reveal and hide his self.

Only existentially true things can be realized as truthful. A psychotic patient may feel that several things are happening around, but much of this might have been his illusions. Ontological insecurity precedes psychosis. A psychotic will feel himself insecure.

An ontologically secure person may encounter all problems though he has a firm sense of identity and reality. A person becomes ontologically insecure when his existential position is under threat. He will not be affected by external events. He may have diverse experiences most of which cannot be shared with others. An ontologically insecure person may be always anxious. His anxiety may be of engulfment, implosion and petrification. Engulfment is understood as a risk in being loved or seen (44). The person often gets misunderstood by others and his lonely

feelings always persist. Ontologically insecure persons experience blankness and this is called implosion. Petrification is behaving in an indifferent manner to everything and everybody. The person will ignore the feelings of others. He/she will depersonalize others and it may appear that he is playing android robot.

Laing has found that the existentially insecure persons often see dreadful nightmares. From the example of a young man, Laing shows that music can reduce ones insecurity. German philosopher Friedrich Wilhelm Nietzsche has actually asked humans to be hard. But hardness in its extreme will only create adverse effects.

Some may become anxious when they are alone, while some are afraid of being in streets. The fear of being in streets is called agoraphobia. Laing narrated an example of a woman who felt ontologically insecure for her parents never took care of her. Her sexual fantasies were for acquiring a sense of security. In her childhood, she had found that her opinions were never accepted. Later, she mistook this and she believed that her identity is not sought after. She was afraid to be like her mother.

All beings are embodied; once they die they are no more. But, there is something disembodied in everyone which include the spiritual elements. The unembodied self is a hyperconscious one. Sometimes, individual's actions may appear different from their real self. This is a result of schizophrenia.

Laing quoted Franz Kafka "you can hold yourself back from the sufferings of the world, this is something you are free to do and is in accord with your nature, but perhaps precisely this holding back is the only suffering that you might be able to avoid". In schizoid condition, there is a persistent conflict between self and body. According to Laing, "the self can relate itself with

immediacy to an object which is an object of its own imagination or memory but not to a real person" (86).

A schizoid person is under constant isolation which is to a large extent the result of self-deception. He will have two or more realities, each of which can be real for him in some instants. His identity cannot be determined for his true self will never be explicit. The person suffers from emptiness, worthlessness, coldness, desolation and dryness. He will have conflicting emotions and will long for what others have and he does not have.

Impersonation is a major distinguishing feature of a schizoid person. According to Laing, "impersonation is a form of identification whereby a part of the individual assumes the identity of a personality he is not" (100). He provides an instance of a girl who is over-conscious and looks in mirror every now and then. Her mother was over-protective and she turned out to be over-dependent on her mother.

Self-consciousness is an "awareness of oneself by oneself, and an awareness of oneself as an object of someone else's observation" (106). A schizoid person is over-conscious and he often tends to believe that he is a material of scrutiny. The person feels that others try to infiltrate into his inner self. Laing points out that if one has stage-fear, we cannot say that it is because of his self-consciousness. Some people want others to look at them, and Laing suggests through the example of a man this might have been the result of schizophrenia. According to Laing, being visible is a basic biological risk and being invisible is a biological defence (112). Self-scrutiny is often the result of one's love for oneself. A self-conscious person likes to show-off his existence. He escapes from social anxiety by avoiding social contacts.

Some people are afraid of being alone and this is called monophobia. This might be the result of psychological tensions. Neurosis is a way of avoiding non-being by avoiding being. A person becomes schizophrenic when his thoughts become conflicting and he cannot hold the pressure of his divided self. In order to get cured, a schizophrenic person will have to estrange himself from his fantasy world which is impossible most of the time.

Laing quotes Jean-Paul Sartre “I am not fond of the word psychological. There is no such thing as the psychological. Let its say that one can improve the biography of the person”. He too ceases to use psychological terms. When we ignore someone who is very self conscious, he will try to establish its identity. This becomes problematic if at all his identity gets split.

He popularized two terms like ‘disconnexion’ and ‘uncoupling’. Disconnexion is the existential distance between one’s self and world. Uncoupling refers to division between true self and false self. The person’s self and his false self might be having oppositional ideologies. It may have constructive or destructive efforts. The person may be urged for life or death.

By this work, Laing has pointed out the situation of those who are labeled as schizophrenic. His study can be regarded an effort to define madness in simple terms.

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